

Express View on import of yellow peas: Pulses need priority

Food and Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi has said that the Centre may stop duty-free imports of yellow peas (matar) after February. This comes even as Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, in her latest budget speech, announced a six-year Mission for Aatmanirbharta (self-reliance) in pulses with a special focus on tur (pigeon-pea), urad (black gram) and masoor (red lentil). It also comes at a time when India's **pulses imports**, at \$3.28 billion during November 2024, **were** 56.6 per cent higher than for the **corresponding** period of the previous year, and **are set to** cross a record \$5 billion in the 2024-25 **fiscal**. The domestic crop was poor last year because of **drought** in Maharashtra and Karnataka, **leading to a spike** in consumer prices. But with retail pulses **inflation easing** to 2.6 per cent in January, from double digit levels through much of last year, the Centre probably does not feel the need to import much now.

India, incidentally, achieved some degree of **self-reliance** in pulses, especially from 2018-19 to 2022-23. That period saw a significant drop in imports, particularly of matar and chana (chickpea). This was enabled by increased domestic production, mainly of chana and moong (green gram), where scientists **bred** shorter-duration varieties requiring one **irrigation** at most. In moong, farmers are today taking as many as four crops a year, **thanks to** varieties that are short-duration as well as photo-thermo insensitive, making them **amenable to** growing anytime and anywhere. The Modi government also helped through some **concerted** efforts at minimum support price (MSP)-based **procurement** of chana and moong. There is definitely a case to extend the success story in the two to other pulses – more so in tur and urad. For that, primacy has to be **accorded** to breeding. The **existing** tur varieties have a duration of 160-180 days. Farmers need varieties that **mature** in 120-130 days, **can** be mechanically harvested and are **resistant** to insect pests and diseases.

Pulses are cultivated largely in lands **prone to** moisture stress. While there is **recognition** of their being a source of protein, less **water-guzzling** than rice, sugarcane or wheat and also **harbouring** rhizobium bacteria that fix atmospheric nitrogen, pulses remain victims of policy **ambiguity**. Tur is now selling below its MSP. It could be the same with chana when the **new crop**, likely a bumper one, **is** harvested in over a month's time. Pulses growers lack the one thing that rice, wheat and sugarcane farmers have – **assurance** of their crop being **procured** at or **fetching** an MSP. They deserve as much if not more.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Corresponding** (adjective) – Equivalent, Matching, Comparable, Parallel, Similar
समरूपी
2. **Set** (to) (verb) – Likely, Expected, Prepared, Ready, Scheduled तैयार
3. **Fiscal** (noun) – Financial, Budgetary, Economic, Monetary, Accounting वित्तीय
4. **Drought** (noun) – Dry spell, Aridity, Water shortage, Scarcity, Dehydration सूखा
5. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Result in, Cause, Bring about, Trigger, Produce वजह बनना
6. **Spike** (noun) – Surge, Increase, Rise, Jump, Peak तेजी
7. **Inflation** (noun) – Price rise, Cost increase, Escalation, Surge, Hike महंगाई
8. **Ease** (verb) – Reduce, Lessen, Alleviate, Mitigate, Relax कम करना
9. **Self-reliance** (noun) – Independence, Autonomy, Self-sufficiency, Self-support, Self-dependence आत्मनिर्भरता
10. **Breed** (verb) – Cultivate, Develop, Produce, Generate, Raise पैदा करना
11. **Irrigation** (noun) – Watering, Cultivation, Hydration, Flooding, Sprinkling सिंचाई
12. **Thanks to** (phrase) – Because of, Due to, Owing to, As a result of, On account of की वजह से
13. **Amenable** (to) (adjective) – Responsive, Adaptable, Open, Receptive, Flexible अनुकूल
14. **Concerted** (adjective) – Coordinated, Joint, Collaborative, Combined, Unified संयुक्त
15. **Procurement** (noun) – Acquisition, Purchase, Buying, Sourcing, Obtaining खरीद
16. **Accord** (to) (verb) – Grant, Give, Allocate, Assign, Bestow प्रदान करना
17. **Existing** (adjective) – Current, Present, Prevailing, Ongoing, Existing मौजूदा
18. **Resistant** (to) (adjective) – Immune, Impervious, Tolerant, Unaffected, Defiant प्रतिरोधी
19. **Prone** (to) (adjective) – Susceptible, Vulnerable, Liable, Inclined, Subject अतिसंवेदनशील
20. **Recognition** (noun) – Acknowledgment, Acceptance, Appreciation, Validation, Approval मान्यता/ पहचान
21. **Water-guzzling** (adjective) – Water-consuming, Thirsty, Water-intensive,

Water-draining, Water-hungry पानी खपत करने वाला

22. **Harbour** (verb) – Contain, Hold, Shelter, Nurture, Foster रखना

23. **Ambiguity** (noun) – Uncertainty, Vagueness, Doubt, Confusion, Obscurity अस्पष्टता

24. **Assurance** (noun) – Guarantee, Promise, Confidence, Certainty, Pledge आश्वासन

25. **Procure** (verb) – Acquire, Obtain, Secure, Purchase, Source प्राप्त करना

26. **Fetch** (verb) – Bring, Earn, Yield, Realize, Command प्राप्त करना

@mocks_wallah

Summary of the Editorial

1. Government's Decision on Yellow Pea Imports

- The Centre is considering stopping duty-free imports of yellow peas (matar) after February.
- This aligns with the government's broader goal of achieving **Aatmanirbharta (self-reliance) in pulses**, as outlined in the Union Budget.

2. Current Pulses Import Scenario

- India's pulses imports surged to **\$3.28 billion in November 2024**, a **56.6% increase** from the previous year.
- Expected to surpass **\$5 billion** in the 2024-25 fiscal year.
- The increase was largely due to **drought-induced crop failures** in Maharashtra and Karnataka, causing a price spike.

3. Inflation Trends and Policy Shift

- Retail **pulses inflation eased to 2.6% in January**, down from double-digit levels last year.
- With prices stabilizing, the government sees less urgency to continue imports.

4. Past Achievements in Pulses Self-Reliance

- Between **2018-19 and 2022-23**, India achieved a degree of **self-sufficiency in pulses**.
- Imports of **chana (chickpea) and matar (yellow pea)** saw a sharp decline.
- Higher domestic production of **chana and moong (green gram)** contributed to this trend.

5. Role of Scientific Innovations

- **Short-duration moong varieties** (requiring minimal irrigation) enabled farmers to take **four crops per year**.
- **Photo-thermo insensitive varieties** made year-round cultivation possible.
- Government support through **MSP-based procurement** helped boost production.

6. Need for Expansion to Other Pulses

- The **success of chana and moong** should be extended to pulses like **tur (pigeon-pea) and urad (black gram)**.
- Focus should be on **breeding shorter-duration varieties (120-130 days)** that:
 - Allow **mechanized harvesting**
 - Are **resistant to pests and diseases**

7. Challenges in Pulses Farming

- Pulses are mainly grown in **moisture-stressed regions**.
- Unlike rice, wheat, and sugarcane, they lack **consistent procurement support** at MSP.

8. Policy Ambiguity & MSP Assurance

- **Tur prices have fallen below MSP**, raising concerns for farmers.
- A **bumper chana crop** could lead to a similar situation.

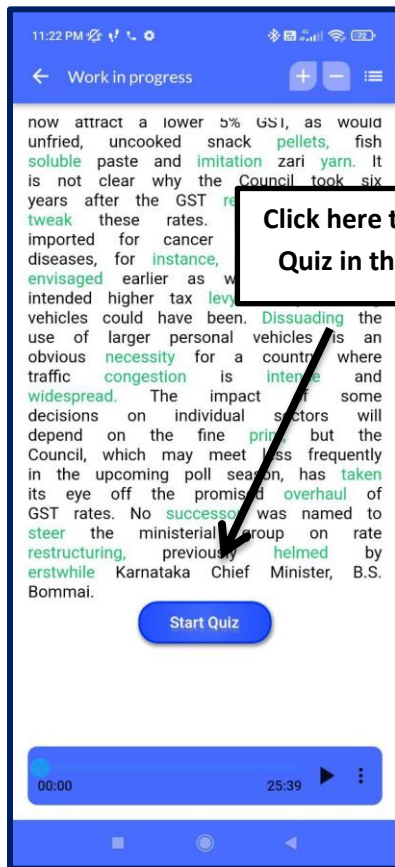
- Pulses farmers need **stronger price assurance and procurement mechanisms**, similar to rice and wheat farmers.

9. **Conclusion: The Need for Policy Reforms**

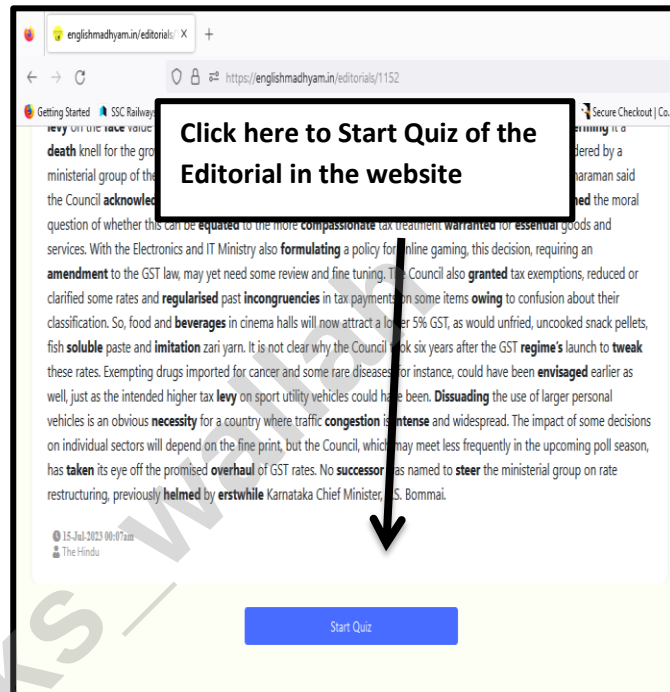
- Instead of relying on **import relaxations**, India must focus on **long-term pulses self-sufficiency**.
- The **procurement system for pulses needs strengthening** to support farmers.
- Investment in **research and better farming techniques** will ensure **sustainable pulses production** in the future.

@mocks_wallah

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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